Did preparations for nuclear war increase the risk of nuclear war? How far did US nuclear weapons deter or compel Soviet behaviour? Indeed, how far did Soviet nuclear weapons deter or compel US behaviour? Did nuclear deterrence work in 1962? How might escalation to full-scale war have come? Did, for example, the discriminate (or accidental) explosion of small numbers of low-yield weapons seriously risk escalation? These questions are still debated. What was the risk of nuclear catastrophe in 1962? To explore these issues, it is useful to begin with Moscow's response to John F. Kennedy's speech of 22 October.

A big war

The first Soviet official to read JFK's speech was the Soviet Ambassador to Washington. Anatoly Dobrynin was summoned to the State Department to meet Secretary of State Rusk one hour before Kennedy appeared on television. In his memoirs, Rusk recounts that when Dobrynin read a copy of the speech, the ambassador 'aged at least 10 years right before my eyes. He reacted as a man in physical shock.'[37] It is commonly accepted that Dobrynin was kept in the dark about the missiles by Moscow. In his memoirs, he recounts that he was in 'moral shock' for years to come at being misled by his government.'[38]

The ambassador repeated Moscow's assurances to Rusk that only 'defensive' weapons were being sent to Cuba. Dobrynin had accompanied the Soviet Foreign Minister, Andrei Gromyko, to the White House on Thursday, 18 October. This was two days after Kennedy was shown photographs of Soviet MRBM sites in western Cuba. Gromyko knew full well about the missiles (even if he had initially expressed concern to Khrushchev about the likely reaction in Washington). He was also aware that Khrushchev had described Operation Anadyr as 'an offensive policy.'[39] The Soviet Foreign Minister, nevertheless, repeated assurances that no 'offensive' weapons were being sent to Cuba. After Gromyko left the Oval Office, Kennedy referred to him as 'that lying bastard.'[40] The President